# Latency Can Reverse the Ranking: Effective-Rate Evaluation of RIS Phase Optimization for Mobile Users

Seda Savaşçı Şen, Ali Çalhan, and Murtaza Cicioğlu

***Abstract*—A walking user changes the radio channel within tens of milliseconds, yet reconfigurable intelligent surface (RIS) phase optimizers are compared by the rate they reach on the channel they were given. We instead evaluate each method on the channel that exists when it finishes, its *effective rate*, with measured latencies, in a 3GPP indoor-office multi-user MISO downlink with a 32-element RIS. First, coordinate descent and long-run Adam, the methods with the highest rate at $t = 0$, need 0.9–5.9 s and lose to a 2.5 ms single-user heuristic. Second, more iterations help only up to a point: at 1.5 m/s Adam's effective rate peaks at 4–6 steps and running it to 48 steps costs 14.0%; at 10 km/h the peak is at 3 steps. The optimum is set by the step time relative to the Doppler frequency, and a small-delay model explains how it scales. Third, a learned update rule that beats tuned Adam at equal steps, and a published phase-aware CNN–LSTM ported to a single user, are both dominated by faster Adam configurations. All results assume the precoder is recomputed from the current channel. For pedestrian users at the measured step cost, latency, not convergence, decides which method is best.**

***Index Terms*—Reconfigurable intelligent surface, mobility, computation latency, effective rate, channel aging, deep unfolding, multi-user MISO.**

## I. Introduction

A reconfigurable intelligent surface (RIS) can turn a blocked corner of a building into a covered one [1]–[4], and prototypes have shown that it works [5], [6]. But it works only if its passive elements steer the signal towards where the user *is*, not towards where the user *was*. Choosing those phases is a hard, non-convex problem, attacked with iterative solvers [2], [7]–[10] and, increasingly, with learned policies [11]. Almost without exception, these methods are compared by the rate they reach on the channel they were given.

That comparison hides a race. A person walking through an office changes the radio channel within tens of milliseconds; a careful solver may need seconds. By the time the best answer is ready, the question has changed. A rough phase delivered on time can then beat an excellent phase delivered late, and running more iterations can make the result worse, not better.

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This paper measures that race. We evaluate every method on the channel that exists when it finishes, its *effective rate*, with latencies measured on a real processor, in the 3GPP indoor-office scenario with walking users [12]. The question is the one a base station (BS) faces: once time is counted, which method should it run, and for how long?

### A. Contributions

1) **A latency-aware criterion.** We define the effective rate (Section IV) and show that under it the solvers with the best rate on paper lose to a single-user heuristic that takes milliseconds, for pedestrian users at the measured step cost.
2) **An optimal number of iterations.** More iterations help only up to a point. The best number of steps is set by a single quantity, the time per step relative to the Doppler frequency, and a small-delay model explains how it scales. The optimum persists for a second classical optimizer, a larger surface and every standardized indoor user speed.
3) **Periodic operation.** When the BS re-optimizes continuously, the pilot overhead decides how often to update, and each update should still be short.
4) **Learning on the clock.** A learned update rule that beats a tuned classical optimizer step for step, loses to it millisecond for millisecond. A published phase-aware CNN–LSTM [13], ported to a single-user version of the scenario, is dominated by a single, faster Adam step.
5) **The price of the main assumption.** All results assume that the BS refreshes its precoder from the current channel; we measure what this assumption is worth.

Section II reviews related work, Section III gives the model, Section IV the evaluation framework, Section V the measurement protocol and Section VI the results; Section VII states what they mean in practice.

## II. Related Work

*RIS phase optimization.* Joint precoding and phase design has been addressed with alternating optimization and semidefinite relaxation [2], practical phase-dependent amplitude models [7], block coordinate descent [8], fractional programming [9], fixed-point and manifold methods [14] and WMMSE [10], [15]. These works report the objective value reached; run time, when discussed, is a complexity order, not a latency measured against the coherence time.

*Learning.* Learned policies include deep reinforcement learning for joint precoding and phase design [11] and learning to reflect directly from pilots [16]. Algorithm unrolling turns an optimizer's iterations into network layers [17]; it has been applied to IRS beamforming [18], MIMO detection [19] and WMMSE precoding [20], [21], and trained networks can approximate WMMSE at a fraction of its run time [22]. Phase-aware regression, which predicts the sine and cosine of each phase, removes the $\pm\pi$ discontinuity of direct phase regression [13]. Learned methods are usually motivated by speed, but that speed is rarely related to how fast the channel changes, and the classical baselines are rarely tuned or timed under the same conditions.

*Mobility and outdated channels.* Mounting the surface on a vehicle turns fast fading into slow fading [23]. Channel aging [24] and outdated channel knowledge [25] have been analysed for RIS, predictive beamforming forecasts the channel of fast UAV links [26], and active sensing tracks mobile users [27]. Aging is classical in massive MIMO [28], [29] and broadcast channels [30]. Two-timescale designs update the phases from channel statistics and the precoder from instantaneous channels [31], [32]. Practical surfaces have a few bits of phase resolution [33], [34]; we use continuous phases. In all of these works the delay between channel acquisition and use is a fixed system parameter; the optimizer's own run time, which differs from method to method and from one iteration count to the next, is not part of the model.

*Gap.* To our knowledge, no RIS work evaluates each method on the channel at its own measured completion time, shows that this creates an optimal iteration count, or compares learned and classical optimizers both at equal steps and at equal measured time.

## III. System and Channel Model

### A. Signal Model

A BS with a uniform linear array of $N_t = 8$ half-wavelength-spaced antennas serves $K = 4$ single-antenna users through a direct link and an RIS of $N = 32$ passive elements (an $8 \times 4$ planar array); Section VI-C also uses $N = 64$. With phases $\boldsymbol{\theta} \in [0, 2\pi)^N$, $\mathbf{v} = e^{j\boldsymbol{\theta}}$ and precoder $\mathbf{W} = [\mathbf{w}_1, \ldots, \mathbf{w}_K]$, user $k$ receives

$$y_k = \big(\mathbf{h}_{d,k}^H + \mathbf{g}_k^H \,\mathrm{diag}(\mathbf{v})\mathbf{F}\big) \sum_{j=1}^{K} \mathbf{w}_j s_j + n_k, \qquad (1)$$

where $\mathbf{F} \in \mathbb{C}^{N \times N_t}$ is the BS–RIS channel, $\mathbf{g}_k^H$ the RIS–user channel, $\mathbf{h}_{d,k}^H$ the direct channel and $n_k \sim \mathcal{CN}(0, \sigma^2)$. With $\mathbf{h}_k^H(\boldsymbol{\theta})$ the bracketed effective channel, user $k$ has rate $R_k = \log_2(1+\mathrm{SINR}_k)$, $\mathrm{SINR}_k = |\mathbf{h}_k^H \mathbf{w}_k|^2 / (\sum_{j \neq k} |\mathbf{h}_k^H \mathbf{w}_j|^2 + \sigma^2)$. The precoder is regularized zero forcing [35] on the effective channel, with regularizer $\lambda = K\sigma^2/P$ and total power $P$. The objective is the minimum user rate, a fairness criterion also used for RIS-assisted MISO in [36],

$$\max_{\boldsymbol{\theta}} \; \min_{k} R_k(\boldsymbol{\theta}), \qquad (2)$$

which Adam and the learned update optimize through the smooth surrogate $-\frac{1}{\beta} \log \sum_k e^{-\beta R_k}$, $\beta = 8$; coordinate descent and the long-run Adam reference maximize the hard minimum.

### B. Geometry and Propagation

The room is $40 \times 20 \times 6$ m (Fig. 1). The RIS is centred at $(20, 0.1, 3)$ m on a wall; the BS is at $(20, 6, 4)$ m, in the panel's boresight and beyond its Fraunhofer distance. Users are dropped uniformly at heights of 1–2 m. The carrier is $f_c = 3$ GHz, the bandwidth 20 MHz, the transmit power 20 dBm, the BS antenna gain 5 dBi and the noise figure 7 dB. All links follow the 3GPP TR 38.901 indoor-office model [12]: its path loss, LoS probability, Ricean factor and log-normal shadowing with Gudmundson correlation [37] at 5 m (TR 38.901 specifies 10 m for LoS and 6 m for NLoS). Non-LoS components come from point scatterers shared by all links of a scenario. The cascaded amplitude follows the two-hop model of [38] with a $\cos^q$ element pattern. Because an RIS is deployed where the direct path is obstructed, the direct link carries an extra 40 dB of loss.

### C. Mobility

Users walk in straight lines at $v = 1.5$ m/s (5.4 km/h) and are reflected at the walls. This lies between the 3 km/h of the 3GPP indoor-hotspot evaluation [39] and the 10 km/h upper end of the IMT-2020 pedestrian class, at which indoor mobility is evaluated [40]; Section VI-D repeats the main measurements at these and higher speeds. Scatterers, path gains, LoS states, shadowing and $\mathbf{F}$ are held fixed; only the users move, and $\mathbf{g}_k(t)$ and $\mathbf{h}_{d,k}(t)$ are recomputed from geometry at every instant. The reference time scale is the Doppler frequency $f_d = v f_c / c = 15$ Hz, with coherence time $T_c = 0.423/f_d = 28.2$ ms [41], [42].

*Limitations.* Fixed scatterers make the channel change less than a real one over seconds, so effective rates beyond 200 ms are optimistic for slow methods; the true values lie between them and the stale floor of Table I. Scattered-path gains are drawn independently per BS antenna, which makes all rates optimistic. The effect of both on the optimal step count is not known. Channel knowledge is perfect apart from the acquisition delay we add. The model is narrowband (no beam squint), and far-field for $N = 32$; for $N = 64$ the BS (6.0 m away) lies just inside the 6.4 m Fraunhofer distance, and the channel uses exact per-element distances.

## IV. Latency-Aware Evaluation Framework

### A. Effective Rate

Let a method $A$ receive the channel $\mathcal{H}(0) = \{\mathbf{F}, \mathbf{g}_k(0), \mathbf{h}_{d,k}(0)\}$, return the phase $\boldsymbol{\theta}_A$, and need the wall-clock time $\tau_A$ to do so.

**Definition 1 (Effective rate).** The effective rate of $A$ is its minimum user rate on the channel that exists when it finishes,

$$R_A^{\mathrm{eff}} = \min_k R_k\big(\boldsymbol{\theta}_A;\, \mathcal{H}(\tau_A)\big), \qquad (3)$$

with the precoder recomputed from $\mathcal{H}(\tau_A)$.

The precoder is a closed-form computation that the BS repeats whenever it has fresh pilots; the RIS phase needs the

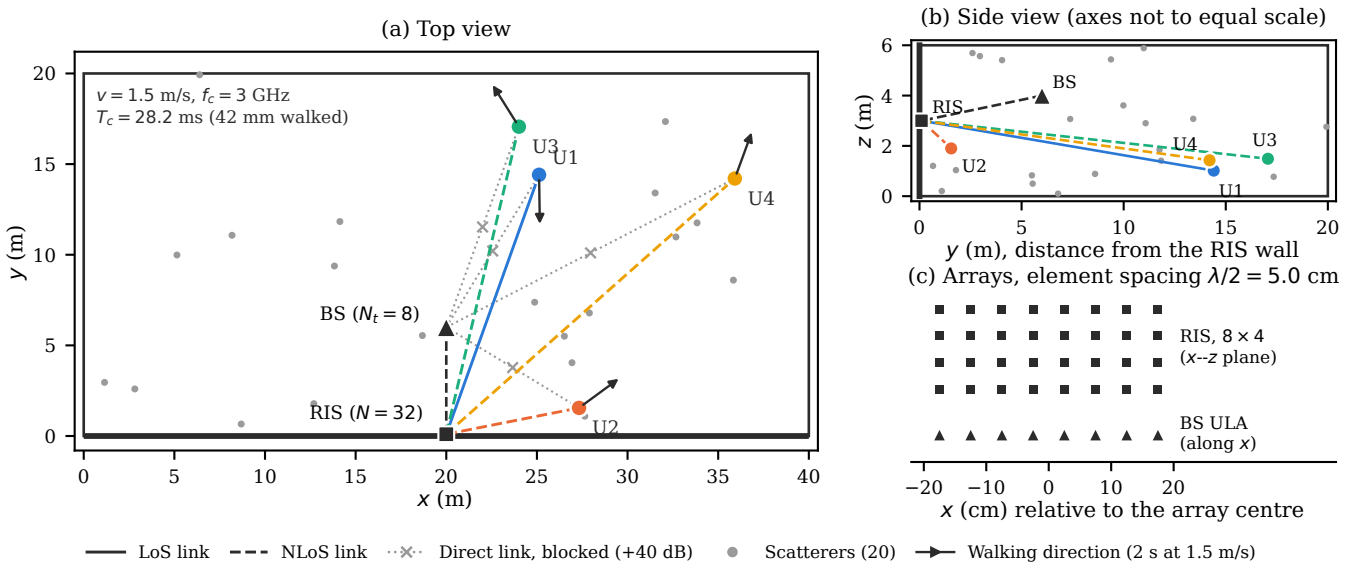



Fig. 1. The simulated scenario, drawn from the first scenario of the aging set exactly as the channel generator produced it. (a) Top view of the $40 \times 20 \times 6$ m office: BS at $(20, 6, 4)$ m, wall-mounted RIS centred at $(20, 0.1, 3)$ m, four users walking at 1.5 m/s, 20 point scatterers. Line style: LoS state of each link. All direct links carry the 40 dB blockage. Arrows: 2 s of walking; within one coherence time a user moves only 42 mm. (b) Side view. (c) Element layouts.

iterative optimization whose latency we measure. Definition 1 therefore lets the phase age and keeps the beam fresh, the same split as in two-timescale designs [31]. Section VI-H prices this assumption.

### B. Why an Optimal Number of Steps Exists

For an iterative method run for $L$ steps, write $r_0(L)$ for its minimum rate at $t = 0$, $\tau(L)$ for its latency, and $\Delta(L) = r_0(L) - \min_k R_k(\boldsymbol{\theta}_L; \mathcal{H}(\tau(L)))$ for the rate lost to aging during its own run time, so that $R^{\text{eff}}(L) = r_0(L) - \Delta(L)$. Each step raises $r_0$ with diminishing returns, while $\Delta$ grows with $\tau$. A step pays off only while

$$r_0(L+1) - r_0(L) \;>\; \Delta(L+1) - \Delta(L), \tag{4}$$

and the effective rate peaks where this fails: the *intrinsic optimum* $L^\star$. It depends on the optimizer, its per-step latency and the speed of the channel together. Whether $R^{\text{eff}}$ is unimodal is an empirical question (Section VI-B).

### C. Equal Steps versus Equal Milliseconds

If one learned step costs $c$ classical steps, an equal-step comparison gives the learned method $c$ times the budget. We therefore also compare at equal measured time.

**Definition 2 (Dominance).** Configuration $B$ dominates $A$ if $\tau_B \le \tau_A$ and $r_{0,B} \ge r_{0,A}$, with one inequality strict.

A dominated configuration is never the better choice, at any latency budget.

### D. Normalized Step Cost and a Small-Delay Model

Channel variation depends on how far a user moves in wavelengths, $f_d\tau$. If an optimizer takes $\Delta T$ per step, its latency after $L$ steps in these units is $Lx$, with

$$x = \Delta T\, f_d. \tag{5}$$

In our model, scaling $\Delta T$ is exactly equivalent to scaling the speed $v$; other carriers are only approximately equivalent, since path loss and the array's size in wavelengths change.

Two approximate regularities, checked in Section VI-C, make (4) explicit. The convergence gap decays roughly as a power law,

$$R_\infty - r_0(L) \approx D\, L^{-\gamma}, \tag{6}$$

and for small delays the aging loss is quadratic in the distance moved, $u = f_d\tau$,

$$\Delta(L, u) \approx \kappa_L\, u^2, \tag{7}$$

as in the leading term of the Clarke correlation, $J_0(2\pi u) \approx 1 - \pi^2 u^2$ [41], [42]. With $u = xL$,

$$R^{\text{eff}}(L) \approx R_\infty - D\, L^{-\gamma} - \kappa\, x^2 L^2. \tag{8}$$

**Proposition 1 (Scaling of the optimum).** For $\gamma, D, \kappa, x > 0$ and $\kappa_L = \kappa$, (8) has a unique maximizer over $L > 0$,

$$L^\star = \left(\frac{\gamma D}{2\kappa}\right)^{\frac{1}{\gamma+2}} x^{-\frac{2}{\gamma+2}}, \tag{9}$$

at which the aging loss equals $\gamma/2$ times the remaining convergence gap.

*Proof.* The derivative $\gamma D L^{-\gamma-1} - 2\kappa x^2 L$ is positive for small $L$, negative for large $L$, and vanishes only at $L^{\gamma+2} = \gamma D/(2\kappa x^2)$; the second derivative is negative. Substituting gives the balance. □

The optimum is thus a power law in $x$ with exponent in $(-1, 0)$: a faster optimizer should run more steps, but less than proportionally more. The derivation assumes $xL^\star \ll 1$, which holds in our range ($xL^\star \le 0.16$). With fitted constants, (9) describes the measurements rather than predicting them independently; its value lies in explaining why the optimum shifts as it does.

### E. Periodic Re-optimization

A deployed controller repeats the optimization with period $U$: it spends $T_{\mathrm{p}}$ on pilots, without data, then $L\Delta T$ on optimization, deploys the result and waits ($U \geq T_{\mathrm{p}} + L\Delta T$; *back-to-back* means equality).

**Definition 3 (Time-averaged effective rate).** With $\boldsymbol{\theta}(t)$ the deployed phase and $\mathcal{P}$ the pilot intervals, over a window $\mathcal{W}$

$$\bar{R}^{\mathrm{eff}} = \frac{1}{|\mathcal{W}|} \int_{\mathcal{W}\setminus\mathcal{P}} \min_k R_k\big(\boldsymbol{\theta}(t);\, \mathcal{H}(t)\big)\, dt. \tag{10}$$

Each update starts from scratch (*cold*) or from the deployed phase (*warm*).

## V. Measurement Protocol

### A. Scenario Sets

All sets use seed 11 unless stated, and numbers from different sets are never mixed in one comparison.

- *Aging set* (Tables I–III, Figs. 2–4): 400 scenarios with walking users and 20 point scatterers, close to the 15–19 clusters of the 3GPP indoor-office model; with $N = 64$, the same construction with an $8 \times 8$ panel.
- *Beam set* (Section VI-H): 400 further scenarios with 6 scatterers.
- *Static set* (Fig. 5): 6000 scenarios without mobility; 4200 for training, 400 for validation, 600 for testing.
- *Single-user set* (Table IV): the aging-set construction with one user, 400 scenarios. The CNN–LSTM is trained on 28 000 of 40 000 static scenarios drawn with seed 2026; 6000 select its checkpoint and Adam's step size, and 6000 form a static test set. The best method is selected on 400 scenarios with seed 12, and the $t = 0$ comparison is repeated on two static draws of 6000 scenarios (seeds 11 and 13).

The generator is not prefix-stable, so every trained model is evaluated with the sample count it was trained with.

### B. Methods

*SU-average* and *SU-best-of* are closed-form single-user phase alignments; the latter keeps the best of $K+1$ candidates. *Adam* [43] optimizes the soft-min surrogate from SU-average. *Armijo* is steepest ascent with Armijo's rule [44] on the same surrogate, with a per-scenario backtracking line search. *Coordinate descent* searches each element over 16 phase levels for up to 8 sweeps; *long-run Adam* runs 1000 iterations from 3 random starts. The *learned update* is a deep-unfolded network with $L$ learned steps that takes the gradient of the soft-min rate as input and exchanges information across users; one network is trained per $L$, without labels.

*Tuning.* On the static set, Adam's step size and objective (soft-min or hard min) are selected on the validation set at every budget: from ten values in $[0.02, 2.0]$ for $L \leq 16$, where 0.75 with the soft-min is selected every time, an interior point, and from six values in $[0.2, 1.5]$ for $L = 24$–$64$. On the aging set Adam uses step size 0.5 (0.25, 0.75 and 1.0 give lower peaks), and Armijo's initial step is chosen from five values (3 is selected); both choices use the reported scenarios, so they are robustness checks rather than held-out selections.

### C. Timing

Latencies are wall-clock times for one scenario on an Intel Xeon CPU at 2.1 GHz with one PyTorch thread; the median over repetitions is kept, and most measurements are repeated in several rounds. They are latencies of unoptimized Python; Section VI-C shows what changes for faster code. The Adam rows use 13.3/8 = 1.66 ms per step, from an earlier two-thread measurement made before a precoder fix, which lies within the 1.49–2.02 ms measured here. On the aging set the load average was 0.20 before and 0.86 after timing (the script's own thread), and the round-to-round spread was 1.15–3.66×. Armijo costs 1.26 times Adam per step (2.09 ms; 0.81–1.97 across scenarios). On the static set the spread was 1.15–1.60×, the load average was not recorded, and the learned network's input features are excluded from its time, which favours it. The $N = 64$ step-time ratio of 1.04 comes from one round on 20 scenarios. On the single-user set the script waits for a load average below 0.5 before timing.

### D. Statistics and Pilots

Effective rates are interpolated on a time grid at each method's latency plus an optional acquisition delay $T_{\mathrm{ov}}$. Because absolute rates vary strongly across scenarios ($\pm$0.17–0.24 b/s/Hz for the means of Table I), methods are compared with a paired bootstrap [45] over scenarios (2000 resamples). Differences of a few thousandths of a b/s/Hz between neighbouring $L$ are not resolved. Best configurations are selected and reported on the same scenarios unless stated, without a multiple-comparison correction, and should be read as estimates.

We tie $T_{\mathrm{ov}}$ and the pilot time $T_{\mathrm{p}}$ to cascaded channel estimation [46]. With the scheme of [47], 48 pilot symbols suffice for $K = 4$, $N = 32$, $N_t = 8$. With 5G NR numerology [48] and one OFDM symbol per pilot they last 3.43, 1.71 and 0.86 ms at 15, 30 and 60 kHz subcarrier spacing; feedback, estimation processing and RIS switching come on top and are not modelled. The periodic controller is simulated on a 0.5 ms grid over 200 ms, with update periods of 10–80 ms or back-to-back, averaging over 100–200 ms.

*Reproducibility.* One script generates every table and figure from stored result files; re-running the aging sweeps reproduces them bit for bit. A separate audit script checks 99 assertions about the learning experiments of the underlying thesis; among the results here it covers those of Sections VI-D and VI-G.

## VI. Results

### A. Slow, Strong Solvers Lose to a Fast Heuristic

In this scenario the RIS carries most of the signal: with the direct links blocked, the median per-user SNR is 20.0 dB for the direct link alone and 31.1 dB through the RIS. Without the RIS the minimum user rate is 1.744 b/s/Hz; a random phase gives 4.072.

Fig. 2 fixes each method's phase at $t = 0$ and follows the minimum rate as users walk. Rates hold for a few milliseconds, drop sharply around $T_c$ and level off above the stale floor. The

TABLE I
RATE AT $t = 0$, LATENCY AND EFFECTIVE RATE (AGING SET, 400 SCENARIOS, 1.5 M/S). STALE FLOOR: $t = 0$ PHASE ON AN INDEPENDENT CHANNEL. †BEYOND THE 200 MS RELIABLE HORIZON; OPTIMISTIC. *VALUE AT THE LAST GRID POINT (5.6 S).

| Method | $t$=0 (b/s/Hz) | Latency (ms) | Effective (b/s/Hz) | Stale (b/s/Hz) |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| No RIS (direct link) | 1.744 | – | – | – |
| Random phase | 4.072 | – | – | – |
| SU-average | 4.624 | 0.42 | 4.623 | 4.315 |
| SU-best-of | 5.276 | 2.5 | 5.272 | 4.336 |
| Adam, $L = 8$ | 6.443 | 13.3 | 5.849 | 4.326 |
| Adam, $L = 12$ | 6.631 | 20.0 | 5.515 | 4.370 |
| Adam, $L = 16$ | 6.754 | 26.6 | 5.324 | 4.381 |
| Adam, $L = 20$ | 6.835 | 33.2 | 5.276 | 4.364 |
| Coord. descent | 6.925 | 880.8 | 4.975† | 4.352 |
| Long-run Adam | 7.117 | 5851.7 | 4.667†* | 4.423 |

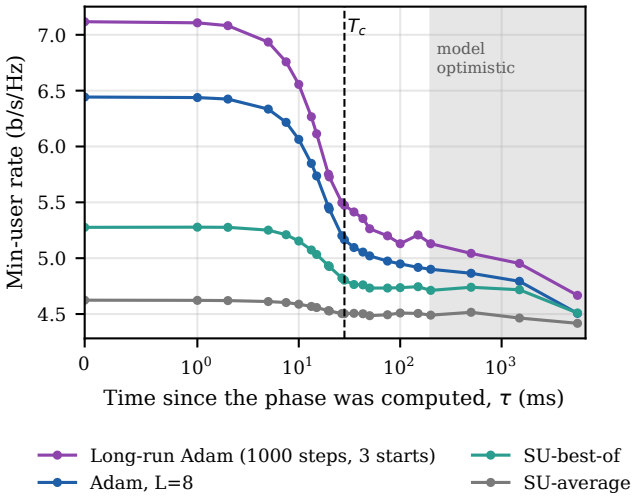



Fig. 2. Minimum user rate of a phase fixed at $t = 0$ as users walk at 1.5 m/s, with the precoder refreshed. Dashed: $T_c = 28.2$ ms. Shaded: beyond 200 ms the model is optimistic.

better a phase was optimized, the more it loses: by $T_c$ long-run Adam falls from 7.117 to 5.473 b/s/Hz, while SU-average only moves from 4.624 to 4.503.

Table I evaluates each method at its own latency. Long-run Adam and coordinate descent have the best $t = 0$ rates of the table, but they need 5.9 s and 0.88 s. By then users have moved metres, and even their optimistic effective rates fall below that of SU-best-of, which takes 2.5 ms: SU-best-of is ahead of coordinate descent by 0.297 b/s/Hz (95% CI 0.204–0.390) and of long-run Adam by 0.604 (0.415–0.805).

### B. More Iterations Stop Helping After a Few Steps

Fig. 3 sweeps the number of Adam steps from SU-average (4.624 b/s/Hz). The $t = 0$ rate rises with every step, from 5.412 at $L = 1$ to 7.037 b/s/Hz at $L = 48$. The effective rate does not: it peaks at $L = 4$–6 (5.980, 5.982 and 5.970 b/s/Hz, at 6.7–10.0 ms), and every other step count is significantly lower. At $L = 48$ it is 14.0% (95% CI 12.5–15.5%) below the peak, although the $t = 0$ rate there is 13.2% higher. In terms

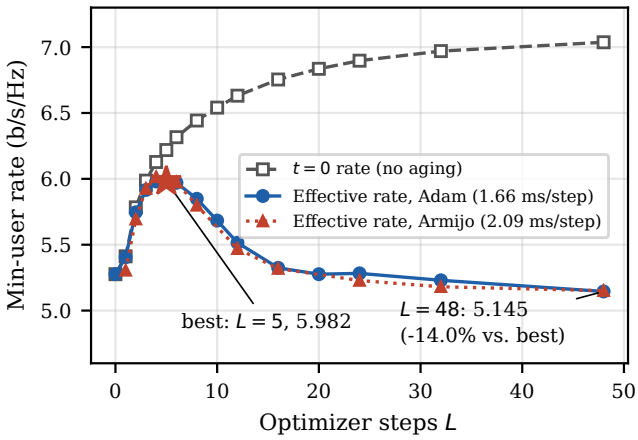



Fig. 3. Step sweep (aging set). The $t = 0$ rate increases with $L$; the effective rate peaks at $L = 4$–6 and is 14.0% lower at $L = 48$. Armijo (2.09 ms per step) shows the same shape. $L = 0$: SU-best-of at 0.05 ms (5.276; 5.272 at its measured 2.5 ms).

of (4), going from $L = 4$ to 6 adds 0.188 b/s/Hz at $t = 0$ but costs 0.198 in aging.

The optimum is not an artefact of Adam or its step size. Step sizes 0.25, 0.75 and 1.0 put it at $L = 6$, 4 and 5, with losses of 11.5%, 13.7% and 11.3% at $L = 48$. Armijo steepest ascent peaks at $L = 4$ (6.015 b/s/Hz). It gains more than Adam in the first steps but costs 1.26 times as much per step, and the two peaks are statistically tied (difference 0.033, CI $-0.001$ to 0.064). With Armijo's per-step cost at 1.0, 1.2, 1.4, 1.6 and 2.0 times Adam's, its best effective rate is $+0.147$, $+0.050$, $-0.013$, $-0.079$ and $-0.197$ b/s/Hz relative to Adam's: even between two classical optimizers, latency decides the ranking.

### C. One Number Sets the Optimum

An optimized implementation would be faster per step. Fig. 4 therefore scales Adam's step time from 0.01 to 3 times the measured value, i.e., $x$ from $2.5\times10^{-4}$ to $7.5\times10^{-2}$; this setup sits at $x = 2.5\times10^{-2}$, and the same axis covers users up to 100 times slower or 3 times faster. The best step count falls steadily: 96 steps at the smallest $x$, 48, 24–32, 12–16, 4–6 here, and 2 at the largest. At the smallest $x$ convergence is nearly free (running to $L = 256$ costs 1.5%, CI 1.3–1.8%); the cost of convergence peaks at about 21% near $x \approx 2.5\times10^{-3}$. For $x \geq 2.5\times10^{-2}$, $L = 256$ lies beyond the 200 ms horizon, so its cost is if anything understated. Whether convergence hurts is therefore a property of the regime, not of RIS optimization in general.

Both laws behind Proposition 1 hold approximately. The aging loss is close to quadratic ($R^2 \geq 0.98$ for every $L$, fitted for $\tau \leq 10$ ms), with $\kappa_L$ growing from 7.8 at $L = 1$ to 25.1 at $L = 48$. The convergence gap is roughly a power law, with $\gamma = 0.93$ but between 0.56 and 1.19 depending on the fit range, so the predicted exponent lies between $-0.78$ and $-0.63$. The measured slope of $L^\star(x)$ is $-0.675$ (95% CI $-0.692$ to $-0.655$), inside that range, so the model pins the exponent down only to about $\pm0.08$; and the closed form (9) is within a factor of 1.27 of the measured optimum at every $x$

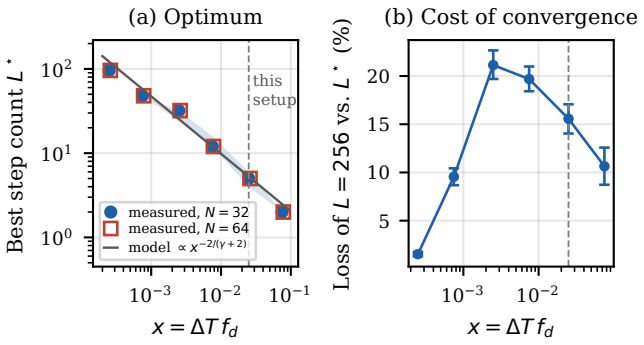



Fig. 4. Adam with its step time scaled from 0.01 to 3 times the measured value. (a) Best step count for $N = 32$ (shaded: not significantly below the best) and $N = 64$; line: closed form (9). (b) Loss of running to $L = 256$ instead of $L^\star$ ($N = 32$), with 95% paired CIs. Dashed: this setup.

(5.3 against 5 here). This is an in-sample check: $\kappa_L$ is fitted over the delays (1.6–10 ms) at which the optima occur. The balance of Proposition 1 does not hold quantitatively (the ratio varies from 0.19 to 1.65), so the model explains where the optimum lies and why it moves, not how the two losses split.

A larger $8 \times 8$ surface ($N = 64$) raises the converged rate (8.48 against 7.10 b/s/Hz) but has the same best step count at every step-time multiplier, which confirms the optimum but not, independently, the exponent. Because its step costs only 1.04 times more in our code, it sits at nearly the same $x$; an implementation whose cost grows with $N$ would move it to fewer steps.

### D. Standardized Speeds and Acquisition Delay

Table II repeats the main measurements on the same scenarios, on a 0.5 ms grid up to 40 ms, at the user speeds of the standards: 3 km/h, used in the 3GPP indoor-hotspot evaluation [39]; 10 km/h, the upper end of the IMT-2020 pedestrian class at which indoor mobility is evaluated [40]; and, beyond the pedestrian class, 18 km/h (5 m/s) and the 30 km/h of the dense-urban evaluation. Without acquisition delay, both findings, an optimal step count and the loss of the slow solvers, hold at every speed. The optimum moves from 8 steps at 3 km/h to 3 at 10 km/h, 2 at 18 km/h and 1 at 30 km/h. Running to $L = 48$ costs 14.5% (95% CI 13.1–16.1%) at 3 km/h and 10.5% (9.0–11.9%) at 10 km/h. SU-best-of is ahead of coordinate descent by 0.25–0.42 b/s/Hz and of long-run Adam by 0.45–0.69 at every speed, with paired CIs above zero (optimistic values for the slow solvers). At 18 and 30 km/h, $L = 48$ lies beyond the reliable horizon (60 and 36 ms), so that cost is approximate. With 3.43 ms of acquisition delay the optimum is not resolved at 18 and 30 km/h, and at 30 km/h SU-best-of and coordinate descent are no longer significantly different. On this finer grid $L = 4$–6 are within 0.5% at 1.5 m/s (14.2% against 14.0% in the main sweep).

A deployed system also spends time on pilots and feedback before optimizing. On the main grid, adding an acquisition delay of 0–10 ms at 1–3 m/s moves the optimum the way (4) predicts (at 1.5 m/s from $L = 4$–6 to $L = 3$–4); excluding

TABLE II
STANDARDIZED AND HIGHER USER SPEEDS (AGING SET, NO ACQUISITION DELAY): COHERENCE TIME, NORMALIZED STEP COST, BEST STEP COUNT (RANGE WITHIN 0.5%), COST OF RUNNING ADAM TO $L = 48$, AND $\Delta$: SU-BEST-OF MINUS COORDINATE DESCENT IN EFFECTIVE RATE (B/S/HZ). †BEYOND THE RELIABLE HORIZON; APPROXIMATE.

| km/h | Source | $T_c$ (ms) | $x$ | $L^\star$ | $L$=48 | $\Delta$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 3 | 3GPP [39] | 50.8 | 0.014 | 8 (6–8) | 14.5% | +0.27 |
| 5.4 | ours | 28.2 | 0.025 | 4 (4–6) | 14.2% | +0.31 |
| 10 | ITU [40] | 15.2 | 0.046 | 3 | 10.5% | +0.25 |
| 18 | ITU, veh. | 8.5 | 0.083 | 2 | 8.0%† | +0.42 |
| 30 | ITU, urban | 5.1 | 0.139 | 1 | 4.3%† | +0.42 |

TABLE III
PERIODIC RE-OPTIMIZATION (AGING SET): BEST UPDATE PERIOD $U$ (MS; B2B = BACK-TO-BACK) AND STEPS PER UPDATE $L$, WITH THE TIME-AVERAGED EFFECTIVE RATE (B/S/HZ) FOR PILOT DURATIONS $T_\mathrm{p}$. WARM−COLD: PAIRED DIFFERENCE OF THE TWO BEST POLICIES; §NOT SIGNIFICANT.

| | Cold start | | | Warm start | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| $T_\mathrm{p}$ (ms) | $U$ | $L$ | rate | $U$ | $L$ | rate | warm−cold |
| 0 | b2b | 3 | 5.83 | b2b | 2 | 6.36 | +0.52 |
| 0.86 | 20 | 4 | 5.20 | 10 | 3 | 5.42 | +0.22 |
| 1.71 | b2b | 48 | 5.09 | 20 | 3 | 5.23 | +0.15 |
| 3.43 | b2b | 48 | 4.98 | 80 | 8 | 4.99 | +0.01§ |

delays above $T_c/2$ (only 3 m/s with 10 ms), running to $L = 48$ costs 2.9–14.7%. The optimum also tolerates a wrong speed assumption: choosing $L$ for 1.5 m/s when users move at 1.8 m/s costs less than 0.5%, and at most 5.7% in our grid.

### E. Periodic Operation: Pilots Set the Period, Updates Stay Short

Table III simulates the controller of Definition 3. Pilot overhead decides how often to update. With free pilots, back-to-back updates with two warm-started steps are best (6.36 b/s/Hz); with 0.86 ms of pilots the best period is 10–20 ms; with 3.43 ms, updates every 80 ms, or back-to-back with 48 steps, which amounts to the same thing. What does not change is that short updates suffice: in every row some policy with at most 8 steps is not significantly below the best. Warm starting gains up to 0.52 b/s/Hz when pilots are short.

### F. A Learned Update Rule Wins per Step but Loses per Millisecond

This comparison uses the static set and $t = 0$ rates, to isolate compute efficiency. At an equal number of steps the learned rule beats tuned Adam at every budget $L \in \{1, 2, 4, 8, 16\}$ (Fig. 5(a)), winning on 68–84% of test scenarios. But one learned step costs 2.7–4.0 Adam steps. On the measured time axis (Fig. 5(b)) every learned configuration is dominated by an Adam configuration that is both faster and better, in each of five timing rounds. For example, the learned rule with $L = 4$ needs 18.41 ms for 5.285 b/s/Hz, while Adam with $L = 8$ needs 13.48 ms for 5.380 b/s/Hz. The equal-step ranking reverses completely. Aging is not included here; since the learned configuration is the slower one in every pair, it would be expected to widen the gap. The cost ratio, however,

is a property of this implementation on one CPU thread: on hardware that accelerates the network's matrix products more than Adam's step, the reversal could weaken.

### G. A Published Phase Predictor Is Beaten by One Gradient Step

We also test a learned predictor published earlier by the authors for a single-antenna BS, the phase-aware CNN–LSTM of [13], which predicts $(\sin\theta_n, \cos\theta_n)$ for every element. We keep the architecture and training recipe of its released code (with z-scored inputs, gradient clipping and best-validation checkpointing from its PyTorch version) and change the input, per element the cascaded channel $g_n\mathbf{F}_n$ and the direct channel, and the label convention. With $N_t > 1$ the common phase of the optimum is barely fixed by the weak direct link, so labels set element 1 to zero and the common phase is restored in closed form, $\phi = \angle(\mathbf{c}^H\mathbf{h}_d)$. The network predicts one user's phase, so we use $K = 1$ and a maximum-ratio precoder; exact element-wise coordinate ascent (CD) provides labels and baseline.

On 6000 static test scenarios the network reaches a phase RMSE of 61.32° and a rate of 12.490 b/s/Hz, between closed-form alignment (12.431) and the optimum (12.893). As a control, on the published single-antenna task the same code reaches 14.99° in our generator, against 2.77° reported in [13] for its own generator, so absolute errors are not comparable across the two studies. With $N_t = 8$ each element's optimal phase depends on the beam formed by all others, and the network captures only a small part of this coupling.

Table IV gives the effective rates. A single Adam step takes 0.59 ms against the network's 1.12 ms and is better by 0.143 b/s/Hz at $t = 0$ (CI 0.089–0.197), and by 0.090 and 0.104 on two larger draws of 6000 scenarios: the network is dominated. At every acquisition delay it is 0.297–0.344 b/s/Hz below the best method, one CD sweep. Used as the start of that sweep, it adds nothing at $t = 0$ and loses 0.028–0.066 b/s/Hz through its extra latency. Against closed-form alignment the network is not significantly different on these 400 scenarios and slightly better on the larger draws. Its original study [13] evaluated a static single-antenna channel; with several BS antennas and moving users, one forward pass buys less than one classical step of half the cost.

### H. The Fresh-Beam Assumption Matters

All results assume that the BS refreshes its precoder from the current channel while only the RIS phase ages. On the beam set, keeping the precoder from $t = 0$ instead makes the rate collapse within tens of milliseconds: at $T_c$ it is 11.7–14.2× lower than with a fresh beam, for every phase choice, and with the phase of Adam ($L = 8$) a precoder only 5 ms old already lowers the rate from 5.228 to 1.736 b/s/Hz (beam-set rates are not comparable with Table I). Refreshing it is cheap (0.12 ms, about 13× less than one Adam step), but it requires effective-channel pilots every few milliseconds, whose airtime we do not charge.

TABLE IV
SINGLE-USER SET (400 SCENARIOS): LATENCY, $t = 0$ RATE AND EFFECTIVE RATE (B/S/HZ) OF THE PORTED CNN–LSTM AND OF CLASSICAL METHODS. BOLD: BEST AT EACH $T_{\mathrm{ov}}$, SELECTED ON A SEPARATE DRAW.

| Method | ms | $t$=0 | Effective, $T_{\mathrm{ov}}$ (ms) 0 | 3.43 | 10 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| SU alignment | 0.04 | 12.389 | 12.389 | 12.369 | 12.249 |
| CD, 1 sweep | 2.48 | 12.709 | **12.698** | **12.656** | **12.491** |
| CD, 2 sweeps | 4.76 | 12.736 | 12.701 | 12.638 | 12.441 |
| CD, 10 sweeps | 23.06 | 12.742 | 12.152 | 12.047 | 11.984 |
| Adam, $L$=1 | 0.59 | 12.499 | 12.498 | 12.472 | 12.339 |
| Adam, $L$=8 | 3.89 | 12.690 | 12.664 | 12.611 | 12.427 |
| CNN–LSTM | 1.12 | 12.355 | 12.354 | 12.326 | 12.193 |
| CNN–LSTM + CD, 1 sweep | 4.26 | 12.700 | 12.671 | 12.614 | 12.424 |
| CD, converged (offline) | – | 12.745 | | | |

## VII. CONCLUSION

We asked which RIS phase optimizer a base station should run when users move, and for how long. Counting the time each method needs, the study shows:

1) **Speed beats precision.** Coordinate descent and long-run Adam need 0.9–5.9 s and lose to a 2.5 ms single-user heuristic, without acquisition delay at every speed from 3 to 30 km/h (with optimistic values for the slow solvers).
2) **A few steps are optimal.** At 1.5 m/s Adam's effective rate peaks at 4–6 steps; running it to 48 steps costs 14.0%. The optimum falls to 3 steps at the 10 km/h of indoor mobility tests.
3) **One number sets the optimum.** The best step count is governed by the step time relative to the Doppler frequency, $x = \Delta T f_d$, and scales approximately as $x^{-2/(\gamma+2)}$ (measured exponent $-0.675$); with a hundredfold faster implementation, convergence becomes nearly free.
4) **Pilots set the update period.** In continuous operation the pilot overhead decides how often to update; each update should still be short.
5) **Learning must win on the clock.** A learned update rule that wins at equal steps (static set, one CPU thread), and a published phase-aware CNN–LSTM ported to a single user, are both dominated by faster classical steps once latency is measured.

In the regime quantified here, latency is therefore not a secondary metric for mobile RIS: it decides which method is best.

*Practical rules.* Choose the number of steps from $x$ and the acquisition delay, not from convergence. Choose the update period from the pilot overhead and keep each update short. Compare methods on measured latency against a classical baseline tuned at each budget, and report dominance rather than equal-step wins.

*Limitations.* The channel model keeps scatterers fixed and draws scattered-path gains independently per BS antenna, which makes long-horizon and absolute rates optimistic. All effective rates assume that the BS recomputes its precoder from the current channel within a few milliseconds, with

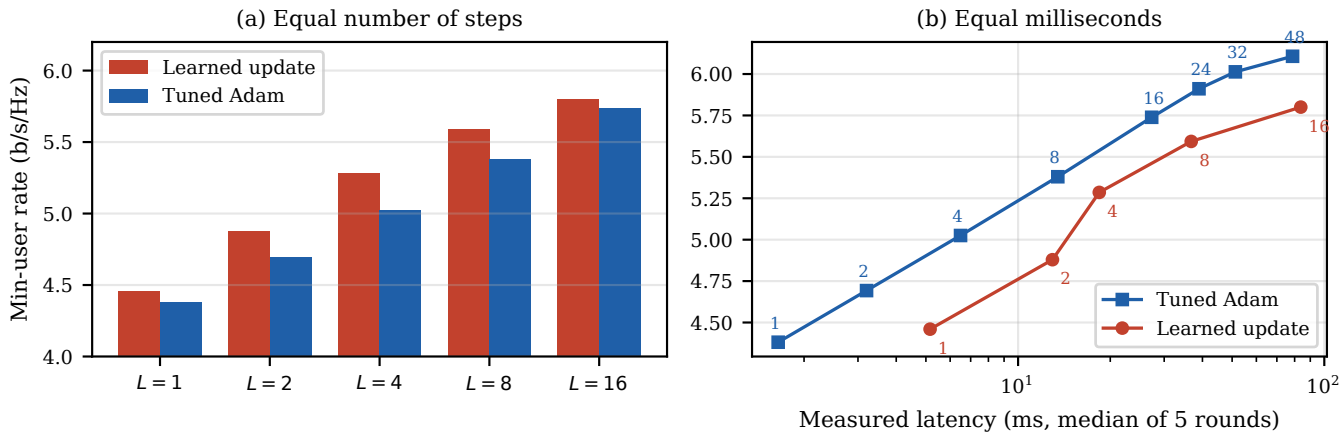



Fig. 5. Learned update rule versus tuned Adam (static test set, 600 scenarios). (a) At equal steps the learned rule is ahead at every budget. (b) On the measured latency axis (numbers: steps), every learned configuration lies below and to the right of the Adam curve: it is dominated.

effective-channel pilots whose airtime we do not charge. Channel knowledge is perfect apart from the delays we add, RIS switching time is not modelled, and the model is narrowband with one geometry. Latencies come from single-threaded Python, and the cost ratio of learned and classical steps on other hardware remains to be measured; the normalized step cost carries the results to faster code and other speeds, and approximately to other carriers. Coordinate descent and long-run Adam were run at fixed budgets; semidefinite relaxation [2], WMMSE [10] and manifold methods were not timed. The CNN–LSTM was ported to a single user only. Imperfect channel knowledge, discrete phases and wideband operation are the natural next steps.

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## Data and Code Availability

The scripts that generate every table and figure, and the stored measurement files they read, are available at [public GitHub repository URL].

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